

Discourse Analysis Resources

Greek III

Contents

The goal of exegesis and the rational for finding relationships between propositions	3
The logical relationships between propositions	6
1. Discourse Analysis	
2. The logical relationships between propositions	
3. Abbreviations for the relationships	
Summary of relationships between propositions	14
Hints for doing logical relationships	17
From discourse analysis to enlightenment: the art of asking questions	19
Conclusion: the question of significance	
Discourse Analysis in a nutshell	23

The goal of exegesis and the rational for finding relationships between propositions

John Piper

A regular assignment in my exegesis classes is to have each student 1) read the passage carefully, 2) determine what the individual propositions are, 3) determine what the relationship between each proposition is, 4) write out each proposition on a separate line with an introductory word or phrase which expresses the relationship between that proposition and the preceding (or following) one, 5) state the single idea which the author intends to communicate in this passage. The paper "How Propositions Relate to Each Other" is designed to initiate students into this habit. But why is it necessary?

In my opinion the goal of exegesis is to think an author's thoughts after him. Or, to put it another way, the goal is to be able to restate an author's original intention in such a way that if he were listening he would agree. The goal is to see reality through another person's eyes.

1 Good exegesis is therefore a very humbling task because it demands that our own ideas take second place. The way we feel or think about life is restrained as we allow ourselves to listen to what the author thinks. When we are exegeting the Scriptures the task is all the more humbling, because the Bible possesses an authority which is absolute; if its ideas about God and his way conflict with our own, we are the ones who change, not the Scriptures. Thus good exegesis is threatening to human pride. For good exegesis runs the risk of discovering that the apostle Paul views life differently than I view it. If I hold his apostolic view to be authoritative, then my view and with it my pride crumbles.

But then can we fallen creatures who proudly love our own glory so much ever do good exegesis? Will we not use every connivance to hide our ignorance? Will we not twist and distort the meaning of Scripture so that it always supports our own view and our own ego? Let's face it, this happens every day. But must it happen? I don't think so.

It is precisely at this point that I believe the Holy Spirit performs his part in the exegetical process for the reliant believer. He does not whisper in our ears the meaning of a text. He cares about the text which he inspired and does not short circuit the study of it. The primary work of the Holy Spirit in exegesis is to abolish the pride and arrogance in us that keep us from being open to the Scriptures. The Holy Spirit makes us teachable because he makes us humble. He causes us to rely wholly on the mercy of God in Christ for our happiness so that we are not threatened if one of our views is found to be wrong. The person who knows himself finite and unworthy and who thus rejoices in the mercy of God has nothing to lose when his ego is threatened.

The fruit of the Spirit is love. This is crucial for exegesis. Love 'seeks not its own, is not puffed up' on the contrary, love 'rejoices in the truth'. This is the mark of the good exegete: he seeks

not his own, he seeks the truth. If the truth he finds conflicts with his own idea he rejoices to have found the truth and humbly acknowledges that 'his own' is wrong.

Therefore the Holy Spirit makes possible the exhilarating experience of growth, for only the open, humble mind truly grows in understanding. The proud mind is more interested in protecting itself than in expanding and correcting itself. It must therefore stay small. Arrogant people are always little people. Humble people look little but they are inheriting the whole world.

So while good exegesis is humbling, it is also tremendously enlarging. It reduces us to our true finiteness that we may see, appropriate and enjoy the magnificent eternal truth revealed in the Scripture.

2 God humbled himself not only in the incarnation of his Son, but also in the inspiration of the Scriptures. The manger and the cross were not sensational. Neither is grammar and syntax. But that is how God has chosen to reveal himself: a poor Jewish peasant and a prepositional phrase have this in common, that they are both human and both ordinary. That the poor peasant was God and the prepositional phrase is the Word of God does not change this fact.

If God humbled himself to take on human flesh and to speak human language then woe to us if we arrogantly presume to ignore the humanity of Christ and the grammar of Scripture. If God has thought it necessary to stoop down and reveal the mystery of his will in Greek and Hebrew syntax, would we not then be presumptuous to seek that revelation apart from that syntax?

If God humbled himself to speak human language, is it surprising that he expects of us the humbling task - not only for the reasons already mentioned, but also because it requires such nitty-gritty, earthy work. None of us has learned to read without much practice and many mistakes - all of which reveals our finiteness and fallibility. Good reading, or good exegesis, is simply an extension of the learning process that began when we were four years old. Then we struggled with 'Sally's hair is curled.' Now we struggle with 'God so loved the world.' Then we asked our mommy what 'curled' means. Now we use concordances and commentaries.

There is no getting away from grammar and syntax. These are the language conventions that carry our intentions. If we do not understand an author's language conventions we cannot understand his meaning. If he says, 'Jack hit the ball' we might think the ball hit Jack, unless we knew the English language convention that the subject comes before the verb and the direct object comes after. And it is not mere quibbling to be concerned about such things - it makes a great deal of difference to Jack whether he hit the ball or the ball hit him.

Therefore since God has spoken to us in a human language and since language communicates only when the reader knows the grammar and syntax, we must make every effort to deal with the Biblical text grammatically. Otherwise the voice of God will remain silent. Only modern day

docetists, who scorn the incarnation, exalt themselves to the point where they think they have a hot line to heaven which can ignore the flesh and bones of the Biblical text.

3 The basic building block in language is a proposition. A proposition is the smallest unit of language which makes an assertion about something. 'Tangerines' is not a proposition. 'I like tangerines' is a proposition. 'Tangerines' is a word, and words are the building blocks of thought. Our main concern in exegesis is to think an author's thoughts, so we are primarily concerned with propositions.

Our main task in understanding an author's thoughts is to determine how his propositions relate to each other. The clearer an author makes these relationships for us, the easier he is to understand. There are places, for example, in John's gospel which are extremely difficult to understand because the relationships between the propositions are only given with a simple 'and'. A literal translation of John 17:9c-11 reads:

17:9c	because they are yours
10a	and all mine are yours
10b	and yours are mine
10c	and I am glorified in them
11a	and no longer am I in the world
11b	and they themselves are in the world
11c	and I am coming to you.

Here we have seven propositions joined by 'and'. But what are the logical relationships among the seven? The word 'and' tells us very little about how Jesus or John conceived the relationships in these three verses. Notice how different the case is with a text from Paul. Romans 1:15-17 reads:

15	I am eager to preach the gospel to you also in Rome
16a	for I am not ashamed of the gospel
16b	for it is the power of God unto salvation.
17a	for in it the righteousness of God is revealed. .

This string of 'for's' makes very plain the structure of Paul's thought: in the gospel God shows himself to be righteous (17a); this makes the gospel a powerful thing which leads to salvation, since there can only be salvation where God is righteous (16b); since the Gospel is the very power of God how silly it would be to be ashamed of it (16a); and since there can be no shame there is only eagerness to proclaim it, even in Rome (15). Verses 16-17 give, therefore, a clear and logical ground for Paul's enthusiastic desire to preach in Rome. Until this relationship between 1:15 and 1:16-17 is seen we have not fully understood Paul. We have not thought his thoughts.

The logical relationships between propositions

(Scott Hafemann)

1. Discourse Analysis

Most students of the Bible do not know how to read (exegete) for understanding. Instead they merely read for information, gladly pouncing upon an author, holding him or her up with their well-trained eye, and then robbing the text of its conclusions. But although their minds become filled with many stolen treasures, they never fool anyone. Everyone knows they are thieves and can be exposed at any time with a good question. The owner's conclusions have merely become the thief's opinions. And such stealing is wrong, even when the opinions in view are biblical opinions.

Discourse analysis is designed to help us become "honest" readers who desire to understand rather than steal. The two best teachers I have ever had both taught me that to *understand* (our goal in exegesis) involves thinking an author's thoughts after him or her. Or to put it another way, the goal of reading the Bible is to be able to restate an author's original intention in such a way that if the author were listening he or she would agree. The goal is to see reality through another person's eyes. But this is simply impossible until one has thought his/her way, *step by step*, after the author. This is where the art/skill of discourse analysis fits in. In discourse analysis we do not attempt to put the author's words into our own - rather, we simply attempt to isolate each proposition (the author's "steps") and to demonstrate how they relate to one another. Having done so, we then can trace the logical development of the author's argument step by step by indicating how the flow of thought moves from logical level to logical level. Finally, after we have a flow chart of the author's argument, we will be able to isolate out each of the author's main logical levels and gain an overview of the argument's development. The result of our labor will be an understanding of the main point of a text and the ways in which it is supported. So discourse analysis has four distinct but related steps:

1. Separate out the individual propositions of the text
2. Determine the logical relationships between the propositions
3. Trace the flow of the argument from step to step
4. Organize the text into its major logical levels, thus establishing its main and supporting points

2. The logical relationships between propositions

The key to any discourse analysis is therefore the ability to separate a text into its constituent propositions and the art of determining their logical interrelationships. Unfortunately, many people do not know what a proposition is, nor what relationships are possible between them. The first gap is easy to fill. With some practice most people are able to recognize propositions in a text, and even become skilled enough to argue over when a certain prepositional or participial phrase ought to be considered to be one or not! By God's grace, the second need has also met its match through the work of Dr. Daniel P. Fuller of Fuller Theological Seminary. Dr. Fuller has done a great service to us in our hermeneutical task by classifying these various relationships and providing us with a vocabulary with which we can talk about them. This material can be found in detail in his *Hermeneutics Syllabus*, copyright 1969. Pasadena, CA. (For sale through the Fuller Seminary bookstore). What follows is taken from that syllabus with his permission.

The relationships between propositions fall into two major classes: ***Coordinate Relationships*** and ***Subordinate Relationships***. Two clauses have a coordinate relationship if one does not support the other in some way, but each is independent and makes its own contribution to the whole. "I ate pickles for lunch and I studied for my Interp class" are two coordinate propositions. They do not support each other, but describe a series of things that I did. Each can stand independent of the other. On the other hand, a proposition has a subordinate relationship to another clause if it supports that clause in some way. For example: "I ate pickles because I had no money" is a compound sentence with two propositions. The second proposition, "because I had no money" is subordinate to the first, providing its ground. "I ate pickles" is thus the main point of this text. ***The main point of a text is that proposition which is supported by all the other propositions and which itself does not support any other.***

There are a number of subclasses under each of these major classes and each of these, together with the typical conjunctions used to indicate them must be mastered.

I. Coordinate Relationships between Propositions (non-supportive)

a. Series: the relationship between propositions, each of which makes its independent contribution to the whole.

Conjunctions: and, moreover, furthermore, likewise (and many more)

Example: Every one who asks receives, **and** he who seeks find, **and** to him who knocks it will be opened (Matthew 7:8)

b. Progression: like a series, but each proposition is a further step toward a climax.

Conjunctions: then (plus others like those under "Series")

Example: Those whom he predestined he called; **and** those whom he called he also justified, **and** those whom he justified he also glorified (Romans 8:30)

c. Alternative: each proposition expresses an opposite possibility arising from a situation.

Conjunctions: but, on the other hand, while, etc.

Example: Some were convinced **while** others disbelieved (Acts 28:24)

II. Subordinate Relationships between Propositions (supportive)

A. Support by Restatement

a. Way-End (Model clause-main clause): the relationship between a statement of an action (end) and one which tells more explicitly what is involved in carrying out this action (way).

Conjunctions: in that, by, etc.

Example: God left not himself without a witness, **in that** he gave you from heaven rains and fruitful seasons (Acts 14:17)

(We speak of the second proposition "supporting" the first here because it is not independent of it but stands in the service of the first proposition, spelling out in more detail the "way" God gave witness).

b. Comparison: the relationship between a statement expressing an action and one making that action clearer by showing what it is like

Conjunctions: even as, as ... so, etc.

Example: my father has sent me, so send I you (John 20:21)

don't
survive

not adversative
which is a
subordinating
relationship in which
one clause stands
in service of the
other clause
→ often concessive

c. Negative-Positive: the relationship between two alternatives, one of which is denied so that the other is enforced. It is also the relationship implicit in contrasting statements.

Conjunctions: not ... but, etc.

Example: "Do **not** be foolish, understand what the will of the Lord is" (Ephesians 5:17; cf. 1 Corinthians 4:10 for an example of contrast).

d. General-Specific: the relationship between a proposition stating a whole and one or more propositions which set forth the parts of the whole.

Example: "Jacob supplanted me these two times: he took away my birthright and now he has taken away my blessing" (Genesis 27:36; cf. 1 Corinthians 9:19-22)

e. Fact-Interpretation: the relationship between an original statement and one clarifying its meaning. The interpreting proposition might define only one word of a preceding proposition. It differs from "General-Specific" in that the interpreting proposition does not set forth a distinguishable part of preceding whole.

speech /
content
clauses →

Example: "And they drunk of the rock that followed them and the rock was Christ" (1 Corinthians 10:4; cf. 1 Corinthians 5:9-11)

B. Support by Distinct Statement

a. Ground (Main clause - Causal clause): the relationship between a statement and the argument or basis on which it stands. In this relationship the supporting proposition follows the supported one.

Conjunctions: for, because, since, etc.

Example: Blessed are the poor in spirit **for** theirs is the Kingdom of heaven (Matthew 5:3; cf. Philippians 2:25-26)

b. Inference (Main clause - Inferential clause: the only difference between this and the "Ground" relationship is that here the supporting proposition always precedes the supported one).

Conjunctions: therefore, wherefore, consequently, accordingly, etc.

Example: The scribes and Pharisees sit in Moses' seat. All these things **therefore**, whatever they bid you, these do and observe (Matthew 23:3; cf. 1 Peter 5:5b-6)

c. Cause-Effect (Main clause - Result clause): the relationship between an action and one automatically consequent upon that action.

Conjunctions: so ... that, that, so that, etc.

Example: God **so** loved the world **that** he gave his only begotten Son (John 3:16)

d. Conditional: this is like the "Cause-Effect" relationship except that the existence of the cause is only potential.

Conjunctions: if ... then, if, provided that, except, etc.

Example: **If** you love me, keep my commandments (John 14:13; cf. Galatians 3:16)

e. Means-End (Main clause - Purpose clause): the relationship between an action and the one that is intended to come as a result.

Conjunctions: in order that, that, with a view to, to the end that, lest, etc.

Example: I long to see you **that** I might impart some spiritual gift to strengthen you (Romans 1:11)

f. Temporal: the relationship between a proposition and the occasion (not quite the cause) when it can occur.

Conjunctions: when, whenever, etc.

Examples: **when** you fast, do not look dismal (Matthew 6:16). Blessed are you **when** men hate you (Luke 6:22).

g. Locative: the relationship between a proposition and the place where it can be true

Conjunctions: where, wherever, etc.

Example: **Where** two or three are gathered together in my name, there I am in their midst (Matthew 18:20)

C. Support by Contrary Statement

a. Adversative (Concessive clause - Main clause): the relationship between a main clause that stands despite a contrary statement, and that contrary statement. The concessive clause "supports" the main clause because it highlights the strength of the main clause which stands despite the obstacle of the concessive clause.

Conjunctions: although ... yet, though, but, nevertheless, etc.

Examples: Though you have 10,000 instructors in Christ, **yet** you do not have many fathers (1 Corinthians 4:15; cf. 1 Corinthians 9:13-13)

b. Question-Answer: this relationship is included here under "C" because, when the answer is opposite that implied or expected in the question, the question behaves like a concessive clause and the relationship is in reality adversative.

Example: Shall we continue in sin that grace may abound? God forbid (Romans 6:1)

But when an answer contains no surprise, it functions like a restatement of the question.

Example: What says the Scripture? Abraham believed God... (Romans 4:3)

c. Situation-Response: this relationship is included here under "C" because when a person responds in a way not intended by the situation that another creates, the situation behaves like a concessive clause and the relationship is in reality adversative.

Example: How often would I have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you would not (Matthew 23:33; cf. Jeremiah 25:4- 7)

But when the response accords with the situation that has been created, then "Situation-Response" behaves like "Cause-Effect"

Example: I did one deed, and you all marvel at it (John 7:21)

3. Abbreviations for the relationships

Most units of thought consist of a series of propositions which is too long and whose logical interrelationships are too complicated for us to hold them suspended in our minds. But in order to gain an overview of an author's argument which is clear enough to allow series interaction with the text, this is precisely what must be done. It thus becomes imperative that we have a way in which we can represent the flow of the argument in symbols so that complicated arguments can be easily followed. The following brackets and their symbols will enable us to accomplish this important task.

I. Coordinate Relationships

- a. Series $s \left[\right.$
- b. Progression $p \left[\right.$
- c. Alternative $Alt \left[\right.$

II. Subordinate Relationships

A. Support by Restatement

- a. Way-End $\begin{matrix} W \\ Ed \end{matrix} \left[\right.$
- b. Comparison $// \left[\right.$
- c. Negative-Positive $\begin{matrix} - \\ + \end{matrix} \left[\right.$
- d. General-Specific $\begin{matrix} Gn \\ Sp \end{matrix} \left[\right.$
- e. Fact-Interpretation $\begin{matrix} Ft \\ In \end{matrix} \left[\right.$

B. Support by Distinct Statement

- a. Ground $_G \left[\right.$
- b. Inference $\therefore \left[\right.$
- c. Cause-Effect $\begin{matrix} C \\ E \end{matrix} \left[\right.$
- d. Conditional $\begin{matrix} C? \\ E \end{matrix} \left[\right.$
- e. Means-End $\begin{matrix} M \\ Ed \end{matrix} \left[\right.$
- f. Temporal $^T \left[\right.$
- g. Locative $^L \left[\right.$

C. Support by Contrary Statement

- a. Adversative ^{Adv} [
- b. Question-Answer ^Q_A [
- c. Situation-Response ^S_R [

Note: G and ∴ must always be placed on the bottom corner of their bracket. Depending on the relationship of the clauses, T, L, //, and Adv may be placed on either corner. Likewise, some other relationships may have their labels reversed, e.g., W-Ed to Ed-W, + - to - +.

Memorize these classifications and their symbols. Now we can begin to do the hard work of reading, a work so difficult (no "speed reading" is real reading!) that a sure sign you have done it will be fatigue. As Mortimer J. Adler put it, "Reading that is reading entails the most intense mental activity. If you are not tired out, you probably have not been doing the work. For from being passive and relaxing, I have always found whet little reading I have done the most arduous and active occupation" (How to Read a Book, 1940 ed., p.110).

Summary of relationships between propositions

Name	Symbol	Definition	Key Words
Series	S	Each proposition makes an independent contribution to the whole	and, moreover, furthermore
Progression	P	Each proposition is a further step towards a climax	then, and, moreover
Alternative	Alt	Each proposition expresses an opposite possibility arising from a situation	but, on the other hand, while, or
Way-End	W Ed	Statement of an action and one which tells more explicitly what is involved in carrying out this action	in that, by
Comparison	//	Statement expressing an action and one making that action clearer by showing what it is like	even as, as...so
Negative-Positive	- +	Two alternatives, one of which is denied so that the other is enforced	not...but
General-Specific	Gn Sp	Proposition stating a whole and one or more which set forth the parts of the whole	
Fact-Interpretation	Ft In	Proposition and one clarifying its meaning; does not set forth a distinguishable part of the preceding whole	
Ground	G	Statement and the argument or basis on which it stands; supporting follows the supported	for, because, since
Inference	∴	As above, but supporting proposition precedes the supported one	therefore, wherefore
Cause-Effect	C E	An action and one automatically consequent upon that action	that, so that
Conditional	C? E	Like above, except the existence of the cause is only potential	if...then, if, except
Means-End	M Ed	An action and the one that is intended to come as a result	In order that, that, lest
Temporal	T	Proposition and the occasion when it can occur	when, whenever
Locative	L	Proposition and the place where it can be true	where, wherever
Adversative	Adv	Main clause that stands despite a contrary statement	although...yet, though, but
Question-Answer	Q A	Statement of question and answer to that question	question mark
Situation-Response	S R	Statement of response to a stated situation or action	

Symbol	Examples
S	- "The sun will be darkened, and the moon will not give its light, and the stars will fall from the sky, and the heavenly bodies will be shaken (Mt. 24:29) - Be joyful in hope, patient in affliction, faithful in prayer. (Rom. 12:12) [doesn't have to have the word 'and'] - For everyone who asks receives, and he who seeks finds, and to him who knocks it will be opened. (Mt. 7:8) - In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. (Jn 1:1)
P	- And those He predestined, He also called; and those whom He called He also justified; and those whom He justified He also glorified. (Rom. 8:30) - The earth produces of itself, first the blade, then the ear, then the full grain in the ear (Mk 4:28) - Then when lust has conceived, it gives birth to sin; and when sin is accomplished, it brings forth death (James 1:15)
Alt	- Some were convinced by what he said, while others disbelieved (Acts 28:24) - Are you He who is to come, or shall we look for another? (Mt. 11:3) - Many of them were saying, "He has a demon and is insane. Why do you listen to Him?" (Jn. 10:20)
W → Ed*	- He emptied Himself by taking the form of a servant (Phil. 2:7) - She brought much gain to her masters by prophesying (Acts 16:16) - Because He has fixed a day in which He will judge the world in righteousness through a Man whom He has appointed, having furnished proof to all men by raising Him from the dead (Acts 17:31) - And yet He did not leave Himself without witness, in that He did good and gave you rains from heaven and fruitful seasons, satisfying your hearts with food and gladness (Acts 14:17)
// → *	- Be imitators of me, just as I also am of Christ (1 Cor. 11:1) - As the Father has sent Me, so send I you (Jn. 20:21) - But we proved to be gentle among you, as a nursing mother tenderly cares for her own children (1 Thess. 2:7)
- → +*	- Do not be foolish, but understand what the will of the Lord is (Eph. 5:17) - We are fools for the sake of Christ, but you are wise in Christ (1 Cor. 4:10)
Gn → Sp*	- Then he said, "Is he not rightly named Jacob, for he has supplanted me these two times? He took away my birthright, and behold, now he has taken away my blessing" (Gen 27:36) - For though I am free from all men, I have made myself a slave to all, so that I may win more. To the Jews I became as a Jew, so that I might win Jews; to those who are under the Law, as under the Law though not being myself under the Law, so that I might win those who are under the Law (1 Cor. 9:19-20)
Ft → In*	- And they drank of the rock that followed them, and the rock was Christ (1 Cor. 10:4) - I wrote you in my letter not to associate with immoral people; ... if he is an immoral person, or covetous... (1 Cor. 5:9-11)
* → G	- Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven (Mt. 5:3) - If they do not have self-control, let them marry, for it is better to marry than to burn (1 Cor. 7:9) - But I thought it necessary to send to you Epaphroditus... because he was longing for you all and was distressed because you had heard that he was sick (Phil. 2:25-26)

Can be started
end

(relative clause)

→ ∴ *	- The end of all things is at hand, therefore, be sensible and sober for prayer (1 Pet. 4:7) - Consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God... Therefore, do not let sin reign in your mortal body (Rom 6:11-12) - Therefore all that they tell you, do and observe, but do not do according to their deeds (Mt. 23:3) - For 'God is opposed to the proud, but gives grace to the humble'. Therefore humble yourselves (1 Pet. 5:5b-6)
C → E*	- There arose a great storm in the sea, so that the boat was being swamped by the waves (Mt. 8:24) - God so loved the world that He gave His only begotten Son (Jn. 3:16)
C? → E*	- If you are led by the Spirit, you are not under law (Gal. 5:18) - If any person is overtaken in any trespass, you the spiritual ones should restore such a one in a spirit of gentleness (Gal 6:1) - If you love me, keep my commandments (Jn. 14:15) - When they heard it, they began to go out one by one (Rom. 8:9) - Unless one is born again he cannot see the kingdom of God (Jn. 3:3) - Walk by the Spirit, and you will not carry out the desire of the flesh (Gal. 5:16)
M → Ed*	- I long to see you, that I might impart some spiritual gift to strengthen you (Rom. 1:11) - For good reason do you reject the command of God in order that you might establish your own tradition (Mk. 7:9) - To the weak I became weak, that I might win the weak; I have become all things to all men, so that I may by all means save some (1 Cor. 9:22)
T → *	- When you fast, do not look gloomy (Mt. 6:16) - Count it all joy, my brothers, whenever you encounter various trials (James 1:2) - Blessed are you when men hate you (Luke 6:22)
L → *	- Where two or three are gathered together in my name, there I am in their midst (Mt. 18:20) - Where the Spirit of the Lord is, there is liberty (2 Cor. 3:17) - Where you go, I will go (Ruth 1:16)
Adv → *	- Although He was a Son, He learned obedience from what He suffered" (Heb. 5:8) - Though you have 10,000 instructors in Christ, yet you do not have many fathers (1 Cor. 4:15) - Do you not know that those who perform sacred services eat the food of the temple (1 Cor. 9:13-15) - For though I am free from all men, I have made myself a slave to all, so that I may win more (1 Cor. 9:19)
Q → A*	- Shall we continue in sin in order that grace might increase? May it never be! (Rom 6:1) - What does the Scripture say? "Abraham believed God..." (Rom. 4:3)
S → R*	- How often I would have gathered your children together as a hen gathers her brood under her wings, and you would not (Mt. 23:38) - And the LORD has sent to you... the prophets. ... "Yet you have not listened to Me," declares the LORD (Jer. 25:4-7)
B L	- For when you judge others you condemn yourself as well, for you the one judging do the same things, therefore, we know that God's judgment is according to the truth upon those who practice such things (Rom 2:1b-2)

Hints for doing logical relationships

1. Think in terms of sub-units within the argument.

- a. Too often it is too easy to just naturally try to relate one line to the following line. whether or not they are directly related in the flow of argument. The goal is not to relate one line to the next, but the component parts in the argument.
- b. Therefore look for to logical connectors within the flow of the argument (i.e. 'so that', 'because', 'for', etc.) and then surmise whether a particular connector is conjoining thoughts WITHIN a particular sub-unit or BETWEEN sub-units in the flow of an argument. In this way you will see how the various building blocks within the argument are put together.

2. Brackets are to be subordinate or superordinate.

- a. Inner brackets are subordinate (these are thoughts within sub-units).
 - When the following proposition supports the preceding proposition, the bracket goes on the *inside* (there may be exceptions).
- b. Outer brackets are superordinate (these are for connecting sub-units together).
 - When the following proposition is supported by the preceding proposition, the bracket goes on the *outside* (there may be exceptions).
- c. Brackets are NEVER to be crossed.

3. **Bracket off your asterisks**, this is how you reflect the logical progression of the argument. That is to say, *all* asterisks must be 'covered' by a Discourse Analysis bracket *except* that asterisk with which you are designating the main point of the passage.

4. General Rules of DA:

- a. Every bracket has an asterisk (except S, some //, or P etc.)
- b. Every bracket must be connected to another (no 'hanging' brackets) and they are to be connected to the asterisked end of that bracket (or the middle of the bracket if there is no asterisk).
- c. Brackets should connect propositions, *not* keywords. They only help you identify the connection.

5. General principles for Your English Translation:

- a. Every logical relationship should be reflected in the translation.
 - i) If you call something a Series. you must translate with 'and'. Do not assume it.
 - ii) If you call something a CE* but you translate with 'after' or 'when', then you have not grasped what the DA is telling you.
 - iii) *This step is the evidence that you understand what you are doing.* Failure to do this correctly reveals a failure to understand the logical flow of the passage. If your logical analysis translated into English does not properly reflect the Greek passage. then you have not done Discourse Analysis correctly — don't fudge your translation. Change your Discourse Analysis!
- b. Only underline Logical Relationship phrases (like 'in order that' etc.). No need to underline the pronoun or the tense of the participle. Those items are carried in the Grammar, not the Logical Analysis.
- c. REPEAT: Every logical relationship should be reflected in your translation!

6. When doing a Translation Comparison:

The point of this part of the assignment is to make you realize that the translators assume certain logical relationships between propositions when they translate. Your task is not to identify the different lexical issues, or the different ordering, or the different choice of pronouns, or the different phrasing, BUT the different Logical Relationship assumed by the translator! If one translates a participle with 'after' and another translates the same participle with 'because', the difference is not in the Greek word or text! The difference is in the Discourse Analysis which, ultimately, is an interpretation of the logical relationships between the propositions in a passage! This is intended to sharpen your skills at doing DA, not merely an exercise in looking at 6 different translations.

Finally... When your logical related flow is complete, look to see that the asterisked unit of thought on the outermost bracket reflects what you believe to be the main point in the argument. If it does not, then your bracketing does not reflect your interpretation of the argument.

From discourse analysis to enlightenment: the art of asking questions

(Scott Hafemann)

Once we have mastered the various logical relationships that can exist between propositions we will be able to discover and determine which relationships actually do exist as the author's argument unfolds. Therefore, our first task in exegesis will be to analyze the discourse by tracing the flow of the argument. Specifically, we will

- a. translate the passage from Greek into a literal English rendering;
- b. then go through the passage isolating the individual propositions. Remember that each proposition must contain both a subject and a predicate. If you deem it necessary to make a participial or prepositional phrase into a separate proposition, you must either convert the participle into a finite verb or supply one for the prepositional phrase;
- c. next, attempt to relate each proposition to what **precedes**: indicate your understanding of the argument by selecting a connecting word or phrase which makes each relationship explicit. Whenever an author supplies such a connecting link (conjunction or phrase), remain faithful to it unless it seems absolutely impossible to do so!
- d. Finally, outline the argument in the margin by using the bracket-method illustrated in class. When you are finished, you should be able to state the main point of the text and all of its supporting points.

But having paraphrased the text, we may be tricked into thinking that we **understand** what an author is up to (for after all, just to get this far is a major accomplishment!). Actually, we have just begun. But we now have something to work with beyond just a vague feeling about the "meaning" of the passage. We now know what our author says. But if this is where we stop, all we have exercised is our memory and a few analytic skills. For in talking about the difference between memory and enlightenment, M.J. Adler writes,

"To be informed is to know simply that something is the case. To be enlightened is to know, in addition, what it is all about: why it is the case, what its connections are with other facts, in what respects it is different, and so forth. This distinction is familiar in terms of the differences between being able to remember something and being able to **explain it**... Enlightenment is achieved only when, in addition to knowing what an author **says** you know what he **means** and **why** he says it" (How to Read a Book, 1972 ed., p.11).

How then do we move from memory to understanding or enlightenment? The answer is simple: **asking questions is the key to understanding!** This does not mean that the exegete has not already asked many, many questions in the process of analyzing the text. Discourse analysis demands that one ask questions of every individual proposition (See the separate hand-out, "Questions to ask yourself in the attempt to determine the logical relationship between propositions"). In the course of discourse analysis most if not all of six of the seven key observational questions will already have been asked (who?, what?, where?, when?, end why?). But even more specifically, all of the questions needed to come to grips with the argument will have been explored. But now it is time to ask those questions that flow out of the seventh general category, "What is going on here?". In asking "what is going on here" kinds of questions, we do not mean at this point asking questions concerning significance (remember the key distinction between the "meaning" and "significance" of a text!). That will come last. At this point we are still working at the exegetical level. All of the questions we must now ask are questions that spring from the text and are to be answered from the same source. And in asking and answering these questions, never go to a commentator until you have allowed yourself the privilege of going to the authors. And do not listen to gossip without a very suspecting ear. You will be able to tell if your questions and answers come from the text by whether or not they are phrased with and supported by ideas that have concrete expression in the text itself, the relevant historical background, or theological presuppositions used by the author (be careful with this last one, however, that what you think is presupposed is actually there).

"What is going on here" questions are questions that come about because one now understands what the author is saying, but what the author is saying seems to raise problems with what the author is saying! For as Dr. Fuller has rightly observed,

"Whenever someone is imparting understanding, or insight, or a new way of looking at things, he will always say things which seem strange and, at the outset, incoherent with other things that he is saying."

Thus, for example, after analyzing Jesus' words in Luke 12:1-7 one is troubled by the observation that Jesus commands his disciples to fear and not to fear God at the same time! How is it that Jesus can warn and comfort his "friends" at the same time? And how do Jesus' words of comfort based on the comparison to the value of the birds hold up in view of the fact that God also throws people into hell? These are questions that flow out of the text and whose answers are essential to really understanding what is going on here! When we are done with our discourse analysis, it will be these "strange...incoherent...things" which will force us to think and understand our author.

"Perhaps you are beginning to see how essential a part of reading it is **to be perplexed and know it**. Wonder is the beginning of wisdom in learning from books as well as from nature. If you never ask yourself any questions about the meaning of a passage, you cannot expect the book to give you any insight you do not already possess" (M.J. Adler, *How to Read a Book*, p.123).

These are profound words and they are certainly true of the book of books as well! When we come to the Bible, our goal is not to read our old, worn ideas back into the text, but to be brought along to new and deeper understandings of the inspired words of the biblical authors. This means that we will never be happy until we read the Scripture carefully enough to be troubled by what we read and then take the time to formulate our problems into questions to ponder and ultimately solve. **Reading = asking questions that you yourself must try to answer in the course of reading!** Here are some general guide lines concerning formulating good questions that I have again taken with his permission from the unpublished work of Dr. D.P. Fuller, this time from a paper he wrote in 1977:

A. Questions should evince troubledness. Ask questions which show, by the way they are stated and by their nature, that they arose from your being troubled by what you observed in the text as you analyzed its discourse. Look hard and long. Since I think Dewey was right (we never do think until we are faced with a problem), questions should pinpoint a problem which first came into your consciousness through a sense of being troubled about something. Experience proves that only when we are faced by a sharply-focused question will our answers represent the sort of thinking that is worthy of studying the Holy Scriptures.

B. Avoid asking a question whose answer is quite obvious or which makes others feel it is being asked primarily to provide an occasion for bringing out some insight that one thinks a verse or passage contains.

C. Avoid vague, strange, abstract language in posing your question. When this kind of language is used it constitutes evidence that the trouble or uneasiness that one feels has not become sufficiently clarified. Remember, you are trying to pinpoint your problem with a question. Work for precision.

D. Substantiate your troubledness, where necessary, from inferences drawn from the text, not your own theological convictions or Christian experience. Primarily, we want to understand the biblical author better, not each other. Besides, you want everyone to feel your problem, otherwise no one will care about the answer. One of the best ways to both pinpoint a problem and evince to all your feelings of troubledness is to pose a question by asking which of the alternatives (both of which have some plausibility!) is true.

E. Avoid asking a question that involves some curiosity arising from something incidental to what is said in the text. If you have a hunch others might think your question is trivial when in fact it is vital for the way you see the author's line of thought to be forming, then point out why it is indeed a vital question.

There are also good and bad ways to formulate your answers, either in papers or in the pulpit, or in your own quiet time when question-asking and answering is very important. Here are some criteria to keep in mind for having good answers:

A. One part of the answer should be a direct affirmation answering the question. This often should be your first statement.

B. Support your answer persuasively by arguments based on the data of the text, and/or some pertinent historical background information, and/or some axiom. Avoid arguing for answers by mere speculation. If we are going to persuade people, then we must base arguments logically on facts, and avoid so-called arguments that consist of speculative plausibility.

C. Avoid verbosity in your question and answer. Confine your answer to the conclusion which answers the question and the arguments which support and lead to your conclusion. Many teachers and preachers lose their audience because they cannot keep to the point.

Conclusion: the question of significance

Of course, the final step in any exegesis done with an eye toward the Church is to ask “so what?” At this point we are now ready to span the centuries, with some help along the way (do not neglect the great theologians, commentators, and preachers through the ages!), by building the ties between the Bible and us. Remember that here the key work is “correspondence”! Our significance will only be as good as the meaning upon which it is built and the analogies that bind our two times and problems together. But if we err, we usually do so at the exegetical end! Mining the meaning of the Bible is hard work. As Francis Bacon once said, “some books are to be tasted, others to be swallowed, and some few to be chewed and digested.” There is no doubt which category the Scriptures fall into, nor that they are worth our effort. Let us set ourselves to the task with dedication and anticipation. We have much to learn and the Church has much to gain from it. For “reading is learning from one who is absent. If you ask a living teacher a question, he will probably answer you. If you are puzzled by what he says, you can save yourself the trouble of thinking by asking him what he means. If, however, you ask a book a question, **you must answer it yourself**... when you question it, it answers you only to the extent that you do the work of thinking and analysis yourself” (Adler, *How to Read a Book*, p.15).

Discourse Analysis in a nutshell

1. Make a literal English translation for your passage.
2. Isolate the individual propositions (each with a subject and predicate) and place one proposition on each line (tab these lines over to about the center of the page).
3. Determine how each proposition relates to its preceding and following propositions (Cause-Effect, Ground, Inference, Comparison, etc.).
4. Insert a connecting word or phrase at the beginning of each line to make the logical relationship explicit.
 - a. When the author supplies a connecting word, use this to help determine the relationship by determining the syntactical and lexical range of the word (e.g. the conjunction *yep* usually introduces a Ground statement—consult BADG or Wallace’s grammar on such words)
 - b. Underline the connecting words or phrases at the start of each line.
5. Trace the argument by inserting brackets in the left margin.
 - a. Begin with the subordinate brackets, connecting the thoughts within the sub-units of the passage.
 - b. Then, Connect the brackets between the sub-units to trace the larger arguments.
 - c. How to connect brackets:
 - i) On each bracket, the end carrying the logical main point should be marked with an asterisk (except for Series, Progressions, Comparisons, etc.).
 - ii) Connect brackets by connecting the asterisks (with Series, etc., draw your bracket from the middle)—every bracket must be connected to another (never more than one).
 - iii) Never cross over lines when drawing brackets.
 - iv) The outermost asterisk on your brackets should indicate the logical main point of the entire passage.
6. Check to make sure that your connecting words/phrases match your D.A. brackets (e.g. an Inference must be indicated by a connecting word like ‘therefore’).

7. Based upon your D.A., write out a one sentence exegetical idea for your passage. Then, reformulate it into a one sentence homiletical idea (the preaching idea).

a. Exegetical Idea

- i) What is the author talking about? —Formulate this as a question.
- ii) What is the author saying about what he is talking about? —Formulate this as the answer to the question.
- iii) Then, merge your question and answer by lopping off the interrogative. This is your exegetical idea.

b. Homiletical Idea

- i) Now, take your exegetical idea and formulate it in a manner that is more directed towards your hearers (focusing upon application).
- ii) This is the phrase that you will repeat over and over throughout your sermon.
- iii) As you move towards application, be aware of the various hermeneutical errors that can be committed even by seasoned exegetes: personalizing, universalizing, spiritualizing, allegorizing, exemplarizing, moralizing, etc.